BCE which led to the setting up of an ambitious missionary programme which saw the most qualified Buddhist monks being despatched to preach the Buddha's gospel beyond the borders of Ashoka's empire. The many inscribed reliquaries recovered by General Alexander Cunningham in 1851 from his excavation of the stupas on Sanchi hill and the surrounding hills, each identifying the names of the elders and missionaries whose ashes they contained, testify that Sanchi came to be regarded by Buddhists as a central necropolis of Buddhism, to which the relics of its saints and its missionaries were brought to be interred.

The Great Stupa at Sanchi, just a few miles east of Bhopal in the central Indian state of Madhya Pradesh, is something of a miracle, being the only one of many from the early years of Buddhism to have survived more or less intact. However, it has no place here, other than in its significance as the jumping-off point from which many of the Buddhist missionaries embarked, most notably Ashoka's son Mahendra by his first known wife, the Buddhist Devi, also known as Vidisha Devi, who had her home in nearby Vidisha town and her own nunnery on Sanchi hill.

All this is set out in the *Mahavamsa*, the 'Great Chronicle' of the island of Lanka, which presents Emperor Ashoka as a hero for his role in bringing Buddhism to the island through his own actions and those of his two children by his wife Devi, Mahendra and Sanghamitta. It tells us that Mahendra and four of his fellow missionaries flew from Vidisha hill (Sanchi) and landed in Lanka on the hill of Mihintale, although it seems more reasonable to assume that they took ship and made their way south along the east coast, halting at various places that were subsequently settled by Buddhist communities and marked by memorials, one of these sites being Amaravati, where the original stupa built there (probably on Ashoka's order) was greatly enlarged over the course of five centuries to become the largest and most impressive stupa complex in South India.